

clear and precise.

<http://hginit.com/>

This tutorial starts off with a small comparison with non-distributed version control systems, and is recommended if you are a Subversion or CVS user.

<http://jemander.se/MercurialByExample.pdf>

This is an excellent tutorial to learn by practice.

Where is Mercurial hosted?

A few well-known source-code-hosting facilities that use Mercurial are BitBucket, Google Code, SourceForge and Codeplex; there are even more out there.

Who uses it?

Mozilla, Vim and Wget are a few popular open source projects that use Mercurial; the developers of the Python programming language have announced that they will make the transition from Subversion to Mercurial soon. *Distutils2*, which is currently being developed outside the Python *stdlib*, also uses Mercurial for version control.

A comparison with Git

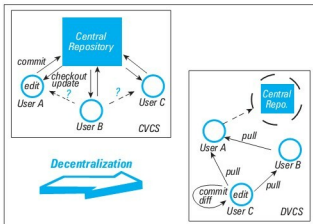
Git is another distributed version control system. Git's design philosophy is unmistakably that of UNIX -- unlike Subversion, CVS, or Mercurial, Git is not one monolithic binary, but a multitude of individual tools. These tools range from high-level 'porcelain' commands such as *git-pull*, *git-merge*, and *git-checkout* to low-level 'plumbing' commands like *git-apply*, *git-hash-object* and *git-merge-file*.

In contrast to Git's philosophy of providing a flexible platform built out of individual components, Mercurial is monolithic and (relatively) inflexible. Developers who like to keep their system clean will probably appreciate the fact that *hg* installs one binary in contrast to the 144 that make up Git; and developers who think that Git's ability to edit your previous commits is unnecessary, and dangerous, will appreciate the simplicity *hg* provides by omitting that particular feature.

No Git tool performs the equivalent of *hg addremove* (a useful Mercurial command that adds all untracked files, and removes all missing files).

BitBucket is to Mercurial what Github is to Git: BitBucket is one of the best hosting sites available for *hg* at present. It is a brilliantly designed site that doesn't just feature a pretty, browsable front-end, but makes it possible to fork anyone's project, make changes, petition for them to be included in the main repository, and pull other people's changes to your branch.

Compared to Git, *hg*'s branching, merging and tagging systems are equally powerful, and only slightly slower. It functions almost identically to Subversion in the commands that it shares, and the new concepts (branching, merging, etc) are easily learned since they are intuitive. While I'm still learning how to do relatively basic things in Git, I've learned pretty much all of *hg*'s functionality in about a day. If you're familiar with Subversion, transitioning to Mercurial should be



CVCS/DVCS data flow comparison



Bitbucket—Mercurial hosting

a piece of cake—the functions you're familiar with are there, and the new functions are easy to learn and well-documented.

Being able to integrate *hg*'s functionality into your own projects is a big plus—and doing that is as easy as importing the required classes and calling the methods, rather than parsing the output of shell scripts (something you might have to do with Git).

Mercurial uses SHA-1 hashes to distinguish between its various revisions. And it supports the HTTP, HTTPS, and SSH protocols for network access to a repository.

All said and done...

Mercurial is a great tool to use for version control, if you have to choose from the various VCSs available out there today. The learning curve for Mercurial is not that steep either, compared to some other DVCSs. Thus, *hg* makes a lot of sense if you're getting started with DVCS, or looking to migrate away from your old client/server VCS.

Have fun! 

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